

Roles, areas and guard rails

Review of the admin and vendor accounts (2026-09-25): who can open what, what was wrong, and what now stops it.

1. The accounts (the SaaS model)

There are three kinds of account, and one rule: **every staff member belongs to exactly one vendor company.**

Who	What they are	Sees	Role and permission
Super admin (lionel@tsokatravel.com)	the platform itself	everything: all companies, plans, subscriptions, users, integrations	administrator , dashboard_access
Vendor company (the owner)	a separate company using the portal, one tenant each	only its own things	vendor , dashboard_vendor_access
Company staff	an employee of one vendor company	only that company's things, and only the parts the owner ticked	vendor_staff (no permissions of its own)
Customer	someone who books	their own bookings, profile, wallet	customer

Staff never enter the admin area, and never see the owner-only pages (team, subscription, API keys, integrations, payouts, wallet). Plans and subscriptions belong to the company, not to individual staff.

2. What was wrong

- 1. The vendor area had no role gate.** A customer with zero permissions could open TourPay, the statement, API keys, integrations, analytics, Tanova, the wallet and payouts. Data stayed scoped to their own user id (nobody saw another business's data), but they could create API keys and invoices with no vendor account. Some pages crashed instead (/user/dashboard , /user/tour , /vendor/payouts).
- 2. Turned away in silence.** A vendor opening an admin page was bounced to their dashboard with no explanation; a stray link could double-redirect through /admin .
- 3. Staff without a vendor account got errors.** The "Vendor Dashboard" link and Payouts returned a 500, with no way back.
- 4. Admin menu entries that dropped staff into the vendor shell.** Tanova opens the vendor layout; the only way back was an "Admin Dashboard" link at the very bottom of the scrolling vendor sidebar. The header had no link.
- 5. TourPay in the admin menu crashed** (500), and its detail page would have used the vendor layout.
- 6. /admin/integrations and the platform legal documents were open to any signed-in person**, so a vendor could rewrite the platform's Terms and Privacy Policy (fixed earlier today).
- 7. 18 admin controllers had no per-permission check** (wallet credit, plan requests, modules, tools, e-mail and SMS tests, statistics, TourPay, availability calendars, template live editor). A limited staff role could reach them.

3. The guard rails now

One map, `config/areas.php`, read by one middleware, `AreaGuard`, and checked by a test.

Area	Who	Permission
staff	the platform team	<code>dashboard_access</code>
vendor	a business	<code>dashboard_vendor_access</code>
account	any signed-in person (profile, own bookings, wallet, security)	none

- **Turned away, never sent in a circle.** Every redirect goes somewhere that person can open: vendor or customer on a staff page goes home; staff without a vendor account on a vendor page goes to `/admin`; a customer on a vendor page goes to their profile. Each carries a visible note saying why. Requests that expect JSON get a 403.
- **Never the upgrade action as a landing page.** `/user/upgrade-vendor` files the vendor request when opened, so customers are sent to their profile, where "Become a vendor" is a deliberate click.
- **Two-way switcher** for people who have both: a "Vendor view" button in the admin header, and a "← Admin" button in the vendor header, always visible.
- **Extra staff permissions** for screens with no check of their own: wallet credit and plan requests need `user_update`; modules, tools, e-mail and SMS tests need `setting_update`; statistics and the credit report need `report_view`; the template live editor needs `template_update`; each availability calendar needs that service's `_update`; TourPay needs `tourpay_view`.
- **Staff TourPay** is now a read-only view across all businesses, in the admin layout (list with totals per currency, filters, and a detail page).
- **Deny by default.** A test lists every admin, user and vendor page and fails if one is not placed in an area, so a new screen cannot ship without someone deciding who it is for.

3a. Sign-up creates a company (built 2026-09-26)

The portal's main sign-up (`/register`, and the vendor form on the public site) now creates a **vendor company**, not a customer. The person becomes the company's owner and adds their own employees as staff from Vendor > Team.

- **The form asks for the company:** company name, owner name, phone, email, password (a strong one), and country and city.
- **Email is verified first.** The vendor area needs a verified email, which stops throwaway sign-ups. The welcome note waits for the first real page.
- **A free trial starts at once** (default 14 days on the cheapest published plan) so a new company can add listings straight away; when it ends, the plan notice says so and only adding listings stops.
- **Admin controls** (Admin > Settings > Vendor): require approval for new companies (they can then sign in but have no vendor access until approved), the trial length (0 = no trial) and which plan the trial uses.
- **The platform team is told** of each new company, and each is recorded as an approved vendor request.
- **Customers who want to become vendors** (an old account) still use "Become a vendor".
- The sign-up is limited to 10 attempts a minute per address, and two bugs that stopped guests using the public vendor form were fixed.

3b. Company staff (built 2026-09-26)

Before this, "team members" did not exist in practice: the Team screen stored an invitation that nothing read, so a team member who signed in got their own empty account. Edit, Save and Delete on that screen had no code behind them, and the invitation's accept link could never be opened (the guest was sent to login, a signed-in person to `/admin`).

- **Attached to one company.** `users.vendor_id` links a person to their company (the tenant resolver already read it; the column never existed). A person can be on one team only.
- **Work as the company.** For the pages a staff member may open, the request runs as the company, so every list, report and record is the company's. Their own profile, password and two-factor stay their own. The audit trail names the real person.
- **The owner decides what each person can open**, by ticking modules: bookings and check-in; customers, loyalty and occasions; catalogue and pricing; finance (TourPay, invoices, statement); marketing; reports and analytics; Tanova trips, inbox and concierge. The company dashboard and Today are always included.
- **Deny by default.** A page in none of the lists is refused, the sidebar and header show only what a person may open, and a test fails if a new page is not placed (`config/staff_access.php`). The booking operations page was caught this way.
- **Adding staff.** The owner enters name, email and modules on Vendor › Team. A new account is created, the person gets an email with a link to choose their password and join, and the owner can change their access, send the invitation again, or remove them at any time (removal ends access at once).
- **Who can be added.** Not yourself, not another company's owner, not a platform account, not someone who already works for another company.
- **The super admin** creates or edits staff on Users: the staff role requires choosing the company, so no staff account exists without one.

4. Access matrix (verified by tests)

Page	Administrator	Staff only	Vendor	Customer
<code>/admin</code> , admin modules	open	open	to their dashboard, with a note	to their profile, with a note
<code>/admin/integrations</code> and legals	open	open	to their dashboard	to their profile
Vendor dashboard, TourPay, API keys	open	to <code>/admin</code> , with a note	open	to their profile, with a note
Profile, own bookings, wallet	open	open	open	open
Staff sections needing an extra permission	open	only with that permission	n/a	n/a

5. Still to decide or do

- `GET /user/upgrade-vendor` **changes data** (creates the request, and can assign the vendor role when auto-approval is on). It should be a POST with a form button.

- **Staff two-factor.** Two-factor sign-in exists but is optional; consider requiring it for staff and for anyone with payout or wallet permissions.
- **Vendor team members.** Confirm what a team member may do inside the owner's business; today it is the vendor role's permissions.
- **Audit trail for staff actions** (wallet credit, plan approvals, module changes): the money ledger and TourPay have one; the admin area does not.
- **Re-check custom roles** when one is created: the extra-permission map covers the screens listed above; other admin screens still rely on the checks inside their own controllers (59 of 78 have them).